

The Little Cardinal's Promise

THE LITTLE CARDINAL'S PROMISE

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CARDINAL PRESS

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For the ones watching the windows.

Rob's dad was the kind of dad
who showed up.



He came to the games Rob won,
and the games Rob lost.

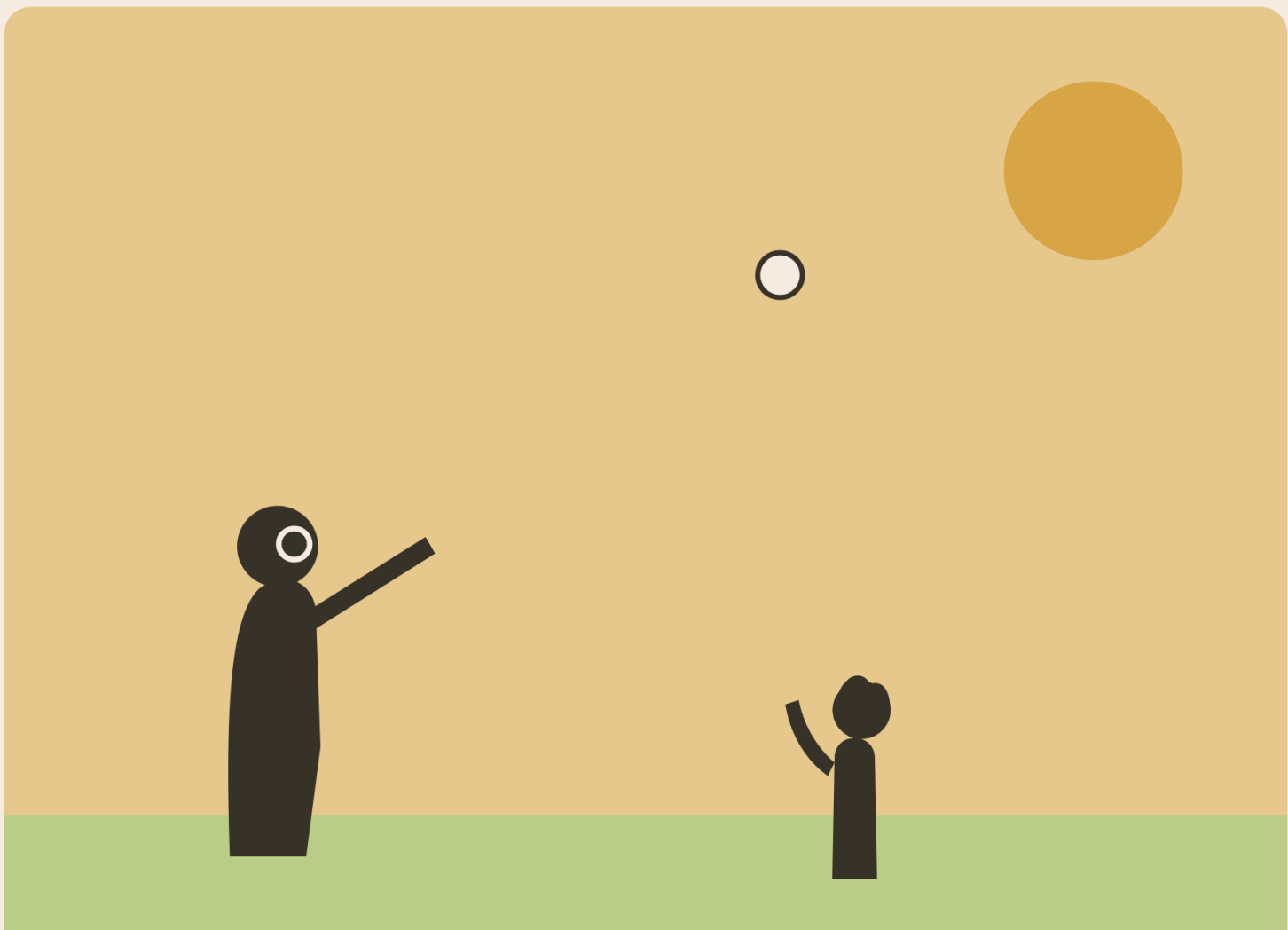
He was always in the third row.
Arms crossed. Watching.



Saturdays were for fly balls.
A hundred of them, then a hundred more.

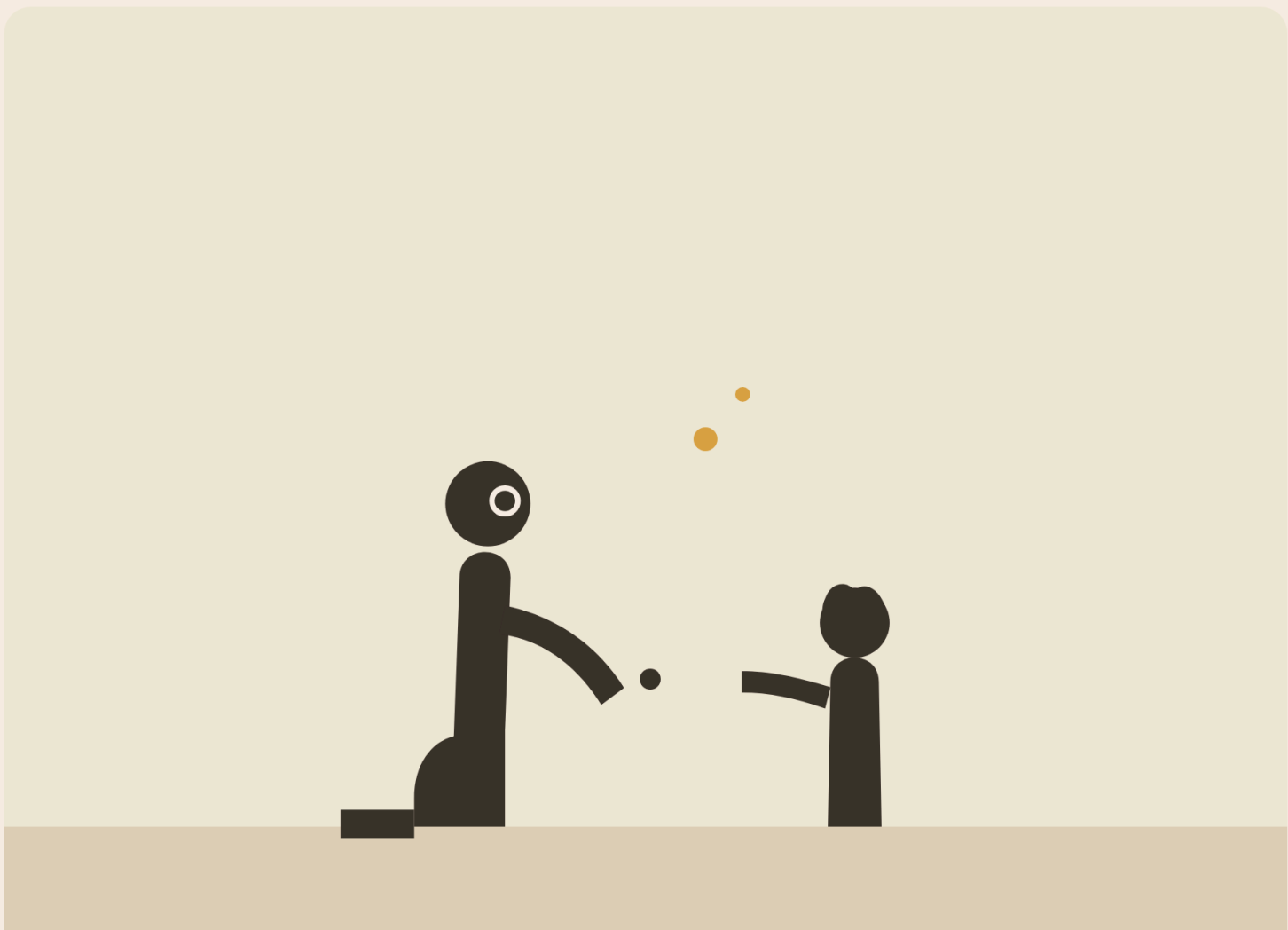
"One more," Dad always said.

It was never just one more.



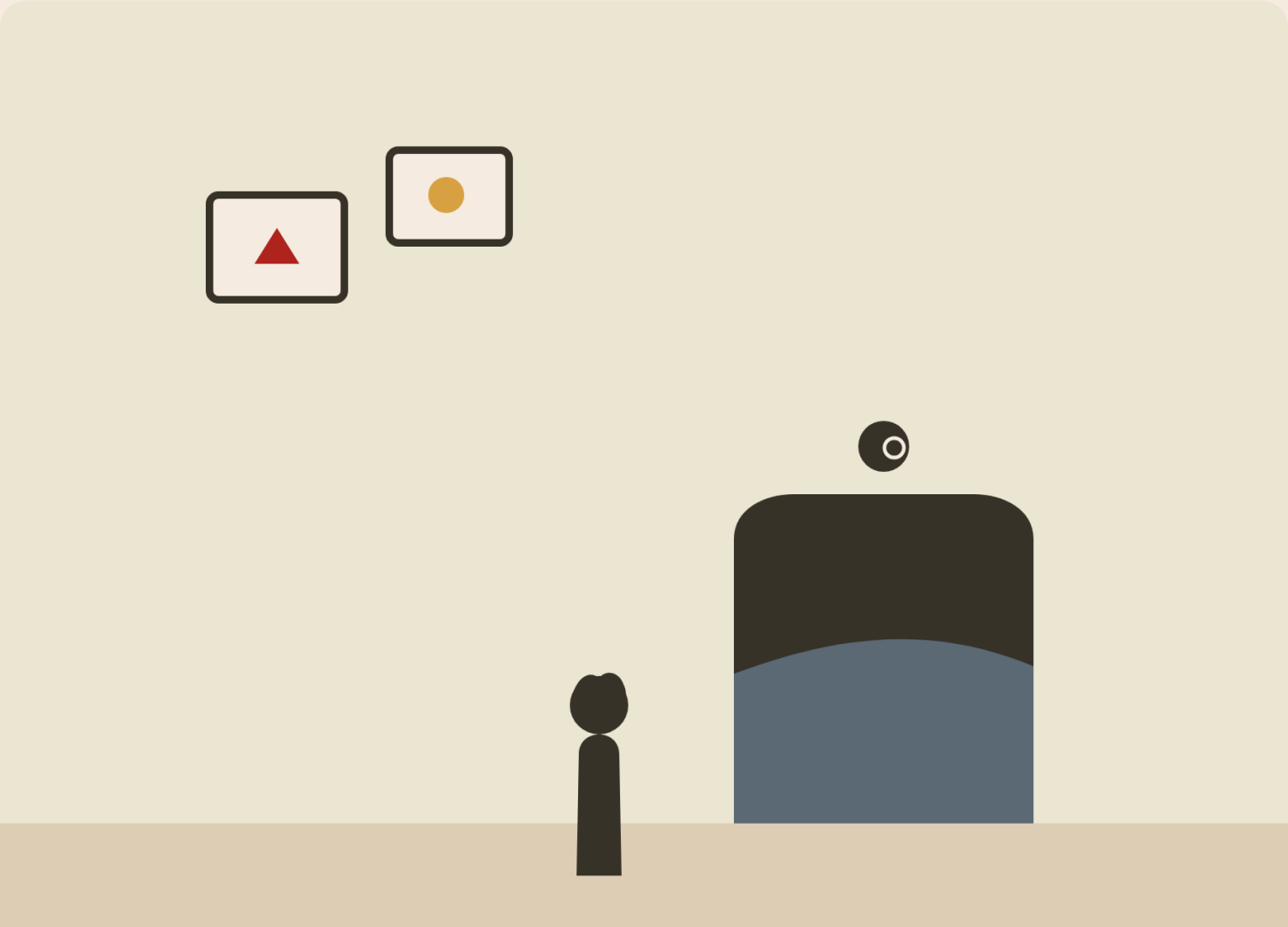
Dad made one promise, and only one.

"No matter what," he said,
"I will always show up for you."



One winter, Dad got sick.
His naps got longer. His voice got softer.

But when Rob sat beside him,
Dad still smiled the smile that meant:
you're mine, and I'm glad.



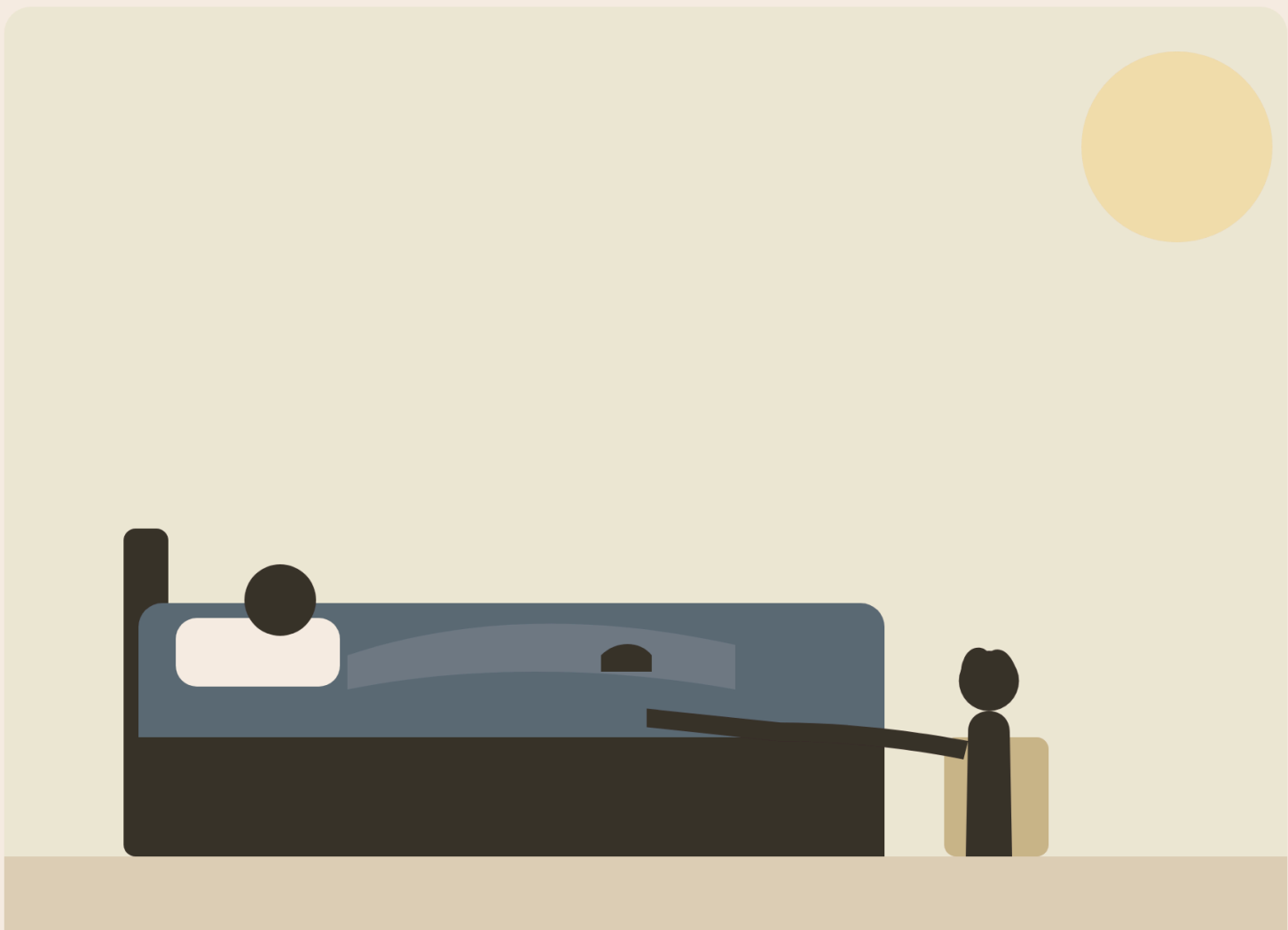
Mama said Dad's body was tired,
and that some tired doesn't get better.

"Then who will show up for me?" Rob asked.

Dad heard him. He held out his hand.

"Watch for me," Dad whispered.

"I keep my promises."



Dad died on a snowy day.

The house got quiet. The truck stayed parked.

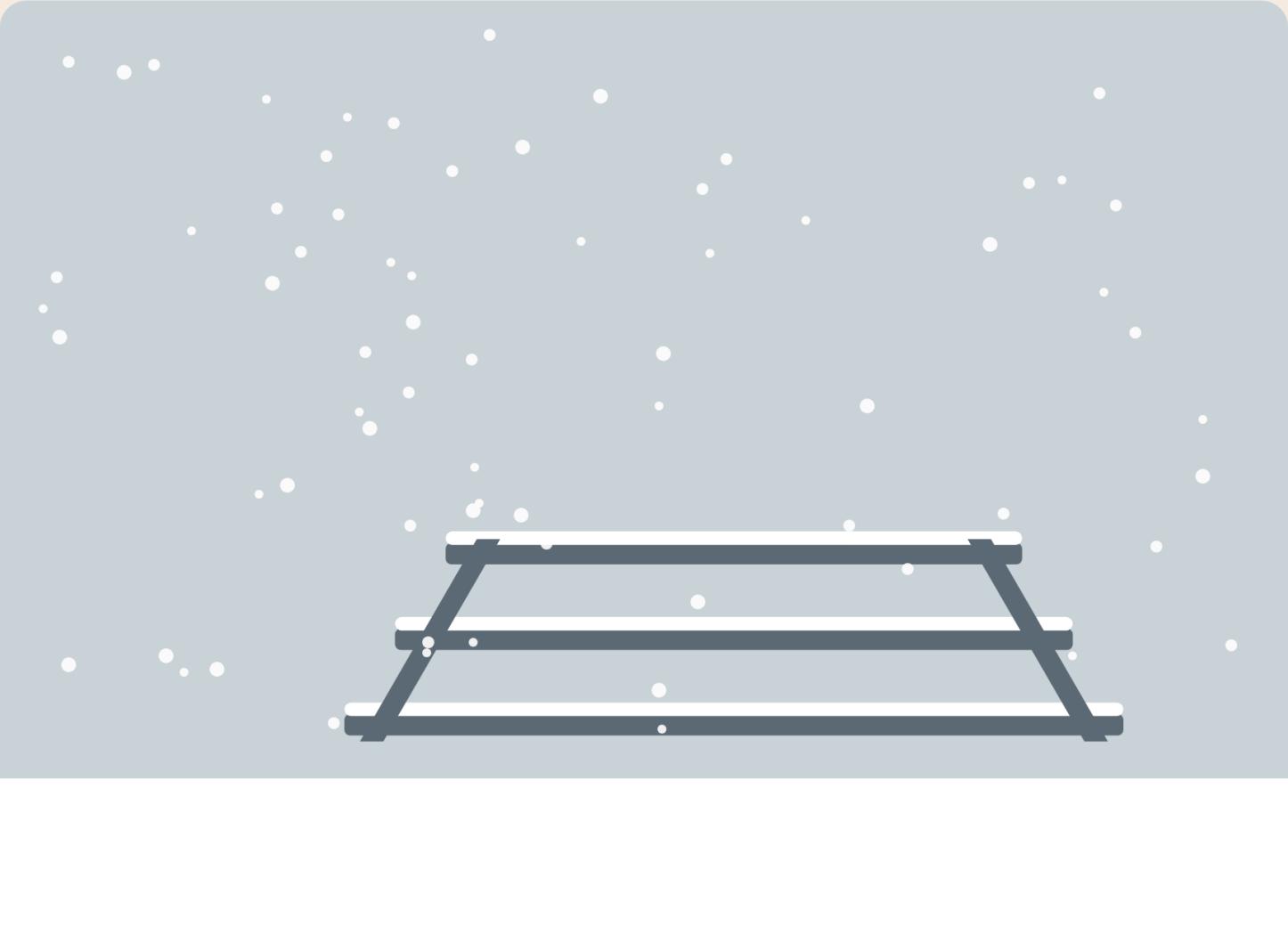
Rob didn't want breakfast.

He didn't want fly balls.

He didn't want anything at all.



The quiet stayed a long time.



One cold morning, Rob heard a tap.

Tap. Tap-tap.



On the window sat a bird.

Not a brown bird. Not a gray bird.

A red bird. Red as Dad's truck.

It looked right at Rob.

And it stayed.



"Mama!" Rob whispered.

"It's not flying away!"

Mama knelt beside him,
and her eyes went shiny.

"You know what some people say about red birds," she
said.

"They say a cardinal is how love shows up... after."



Rob put his hand against the cold glass.

"You came," he said.

"You kept your promise."

The cardinal tipped its head —

the way Dad did

when he was proud and didn't say so.



The cardinal didn't come every day.

But it came.

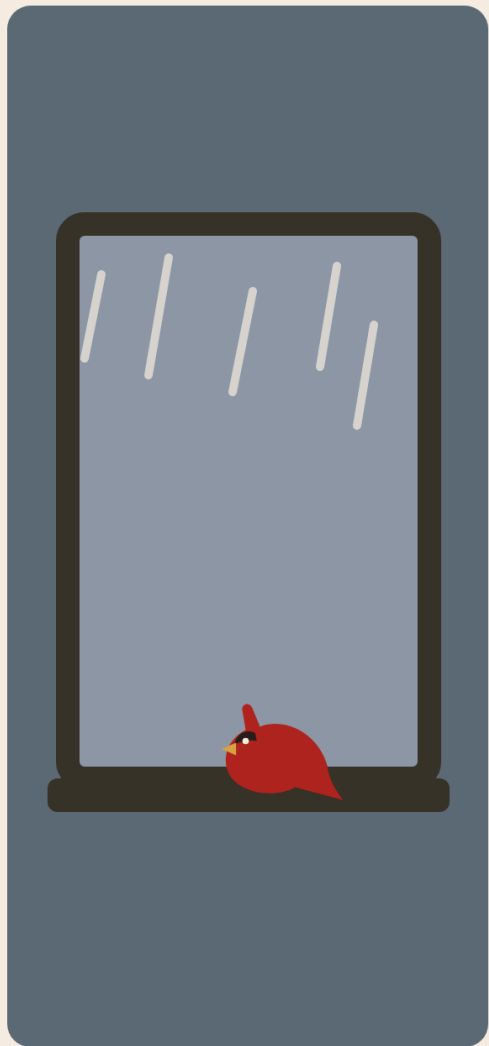
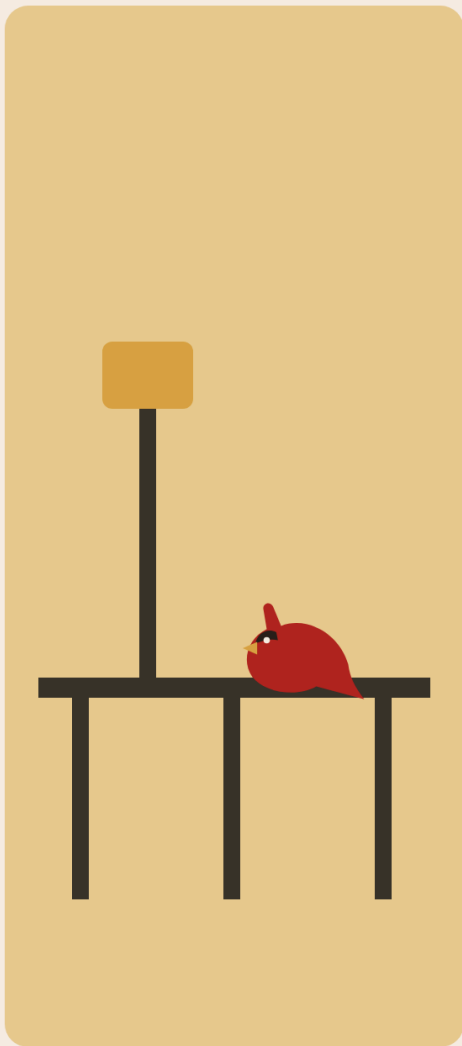
On the first day of school.

At the last game of the season.

On days when Rob missed Dad

so much his chest hurt —

tap. Tap-tap.

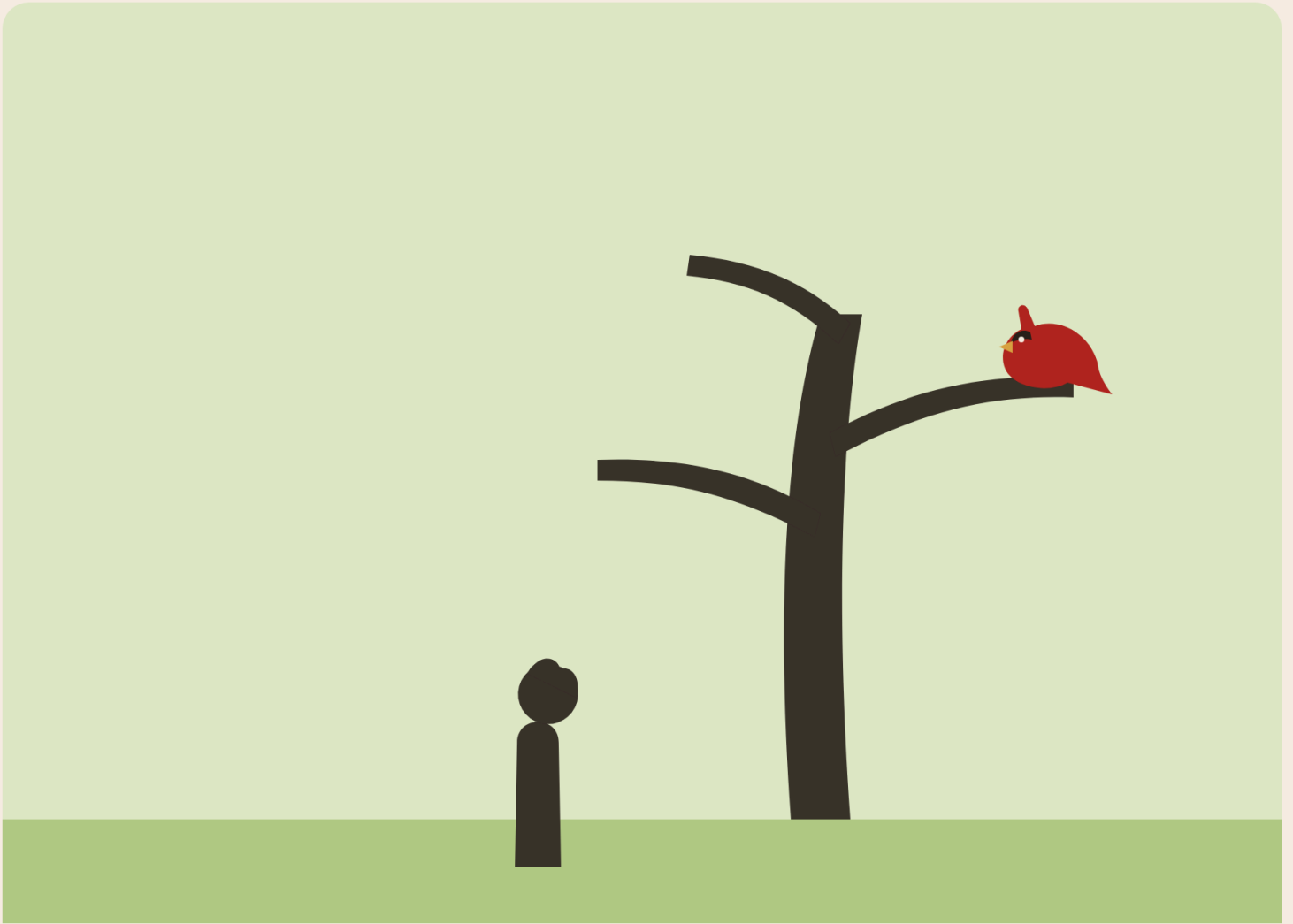


And when it came,
Rob always said the same thing.

"I see you. I love you too."

Because love that shows up
doesn't stop showing up.

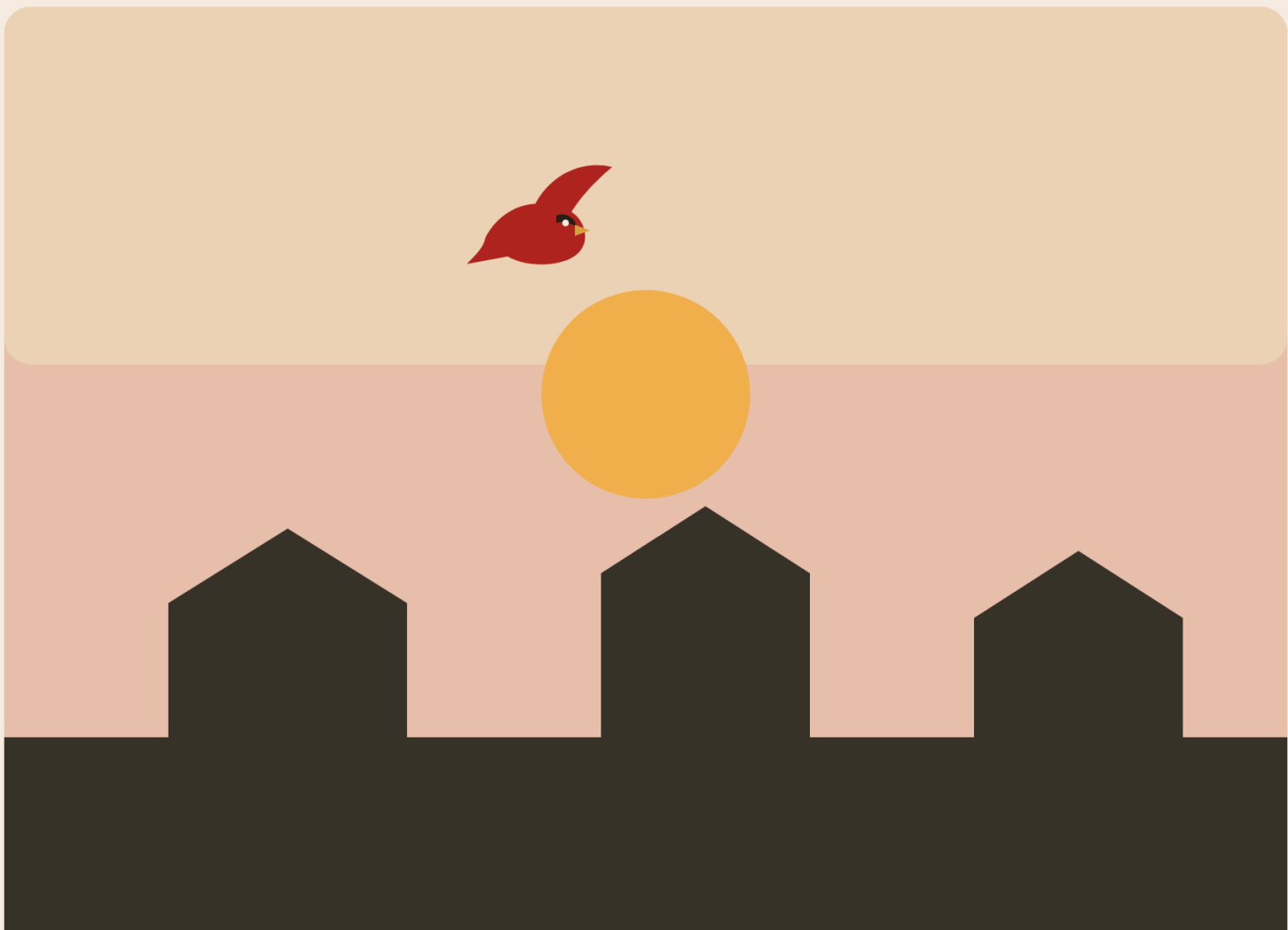
It just changes where it sits.



Now, when the world feels too quiet...
watch the windows.

Watch the fences and the branches and the snow.

Red keeps its promises.



A NOTE FOR GROWN-UPS

When you talk with a child about death, use the real words. Say died, not went to sleep. Let them see that you miss the person too; grief shared is grief halved, even for the smallest hearts.

And when a red bird lands, let it be a comfort without being a test. The point was never the bird. The point is that love that showed up keeps showing up. It just changes where it sits.

*The true story of the cardinal is told in the author's memoir, *The Cardinal's Promise*.*